MAKING SPACE TOOLKIT · 04

Workload Decision Guide

Choose the right intervention - including the option of no technology

START WITH THE PURPOSE

What outcome is essential for pupils, staff, compliance or school improvement? Is the task itself necessary, or only its outcome?

FIVE PATHWAYS

PATHWAY	CHOOSE IT WHEN...	WHAT TO DO
REMOVE	The task has little value, no clear requirement, or duplicates another process.	Stop it. Confirm dependencies and decision authority first.
REDESIGN	The outcome matters but the steps are cumbersome.	Simplify approvals, reduce fields, combine systems, clarify ownership or change frequency.
AUTOMATE	The process is stable, repetitive and rules-based.	Explore forms, routing, reminders, document generation or system integrations. Check exceptions and maintenance.
AI-ASSIST	Drafting, synthesising, translating, ideation or technical problem-solving would help.	Use an approved AI tool with human checking and appropriate data controls.
LEAVE ALONE / PROTECT	The task is inherently relational or professional, or a change would add risk or complexity.	Retain the human-led process and consider other support.

Several pathways can be combined.

DECISION CHECKS

- ☐ Is the work genuinely necessary?
- ☐ Who benefits?
- ☐ What must stay human?
- ☐ Does the fix shift workload elsewhere?
- ☐ Is it safe and compliant?
- ☐ Who maintains it?
- ☐ How will we know it helped?

KEY PRINCIPLE

PROTECT before RETHINK.

Technology is an option, not the objective.

Informed by: **EEF** Workload Review · **DfE** Conversation Guide for Workload and Wellbeing · **DfE** Staff Workload Survey

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